GOA

A QUESTION OF METTLE AND ORE

By Kiran D. Tare

On March 21, 11 days after the BJP won 20 of the 40 assembly seats in Goa (one short of a simple majority), the party ended the suspense and announced that incumbent chief minister Pramod Sawant would continue to lead the state government. Stability is not an issue. Almost as soon as the results were out, the Maharashtrawadi Gomantak Party (MGP) announced its "unconditional support". Three Independents—Chandrakant Shetye, Alexio Reginald Lourenco and Antonio Vaz—are also now onboard, so the party has the support of 25 MLAs.

Sawant wasn't an automatic choice, five-time MLA Vishwajeet Rane had his hat in the ring too. Rane represents Valpoi constituency next door to Sawant's Sankhali. They have a similar socio-economic profile too, coming as they do from the Maratha community, which is very influential in north Goa. Sawant is an Ayurvedic doctor while Rane has a degree in business administration. Rane, who switched over to the BJP from the



ORE AND DUST
Vedanta's mine in Goa's Codli, now abandoned; (inset) second term CM Pramod Sawant

MILIND SHELTE